

An Ethics of Care

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Why ethics?

A key concern for education and educators is the development of well-mannered and moral learners. The philosophical field concerned with what is considered morally good and morally bad is called 'ethics' (Singer, 2022). It is the field that looks into the questions regarding what is right and what is wrong behaviour in the world, and how we can go about determining those rights and wrongs. If part of our, the educators', task is to develop morally upright and responsible citizens (Sayed & Vellanki, 2013), it follows that we should be concerned with ethics as well. How else are we to evaluate what is the 'right' way to be or to do something, let alone the 'right' way to teach, if we do not invest time in understanding ethics?

Forms of ethics and critique

Historically, especially in the Western philosophical traditions, there are three strands of ethics that had considerable influence on education (Noddings, 2005): virtue ethics, deontological ethics and consequentialist ethics. Deontological ethics, or normative ethics, consider rules and duties as the foundations of ethics (Hursthouse and Pettigrove, 2008). What follows as ethical behaviour or requirements are those behaviours and decisions that fall in line with pre-established rules and duties. Consequentialist ethics consider the moral path as the one that leads to the greatest happiness or 'good' (Hursthouse and Pettigrove, 2008). As the name suggests, consequentialism focuses on 'consequences'. In this case, what is right is what leads to the greater good. Virtue ethics takes a different route to rules and consequences, and focuses on what could be considered as moral character and virtues for humanity (Hursthouse and Pettigrove, 2008).

As examples of how these may be applied in the classroom environment, we can consider the following:

- a) "My classroom rules tell my learners what is right and expected in my classroom."

This is an example of deontological ethics. We determine right and wrong behaviour based on the rules and duties that are established for us.

- b) "The department declared that English will be the primary LOLT, so we can ensure equal opportunity learning for the majority of our learners."

In the above statement the 'right approach' to teaching and learning is determined on the basis of what events are leading to the greater good – that the majority of learners will have fair access to learning if the department and schools approach education in a particular way.

- c) "Cindy, do not lie! Only bad people lie!"

As a very simple example, the final statement portrays virtue ethics - as it implies what is required to be a person of good moral character. In this case, being honest

and truthful are considered virtues and characteristics that moral people should strive for. In this sense it also depicts the difference between virtue ethics and the other two forms of ethics – whilst the first two focus on external rules and effects, virtue ethics looks towards the self. In other words, it focuses on guiding decisions based on one's being and character (Hursthouse and Pettigrove, 2008).

It does not take much effort to see how these strands of ethics conflict with each other or lead to very different outcomes in terms of what 'ought to' be done. For example, what if a rule leads to the exclusion of a lot of learners? Should we follow the rule? (consequentialist critique of deontology). Or, what if our assessment policy focussed on the highest possible pass rate leads to the exclusion or even harm of a few students? Do we not have a duty towards all? (deontological/virtue critique of consequentialism). Or, should we always tell the truth? Are we good people if we tell people they are not as proficient/pretty/skilled as others? Is it not better if we only remain honest most of the time? Not even asking how we come to determine what the virtues we should be pursuing are and in which contexts they apply (consequentialist critique of virtue ethics).

It is clear from the above that it is hard to find firm, unquestionable answers for ethics. What makes it even more complicated is when we include systems and institutions that will have long term effects for the wellbeing of people – as is the case with schools – into the equation. The 21st century European ethicist and highly influential philosopher on contemporary philosophies and theories, Paul Ricoeur made a proposal that the route forward for moral philosophy in the context of our contemporary world and its influential institutions is to bring together independent positions of discernment (i.e. external principles) with moral characters that promote compassion (i.e. moral personality traits)(Leget, 2011). This position seems to be the one held by proponents of an ethics of care. A central tenet held by key proponents of an ethics of care, such as Noddings (2005), Gillian (Joost, 2011) and Tronto (Grypdonck, 2011), is that our very being requires compassion and care for survival and therefore should require compassion and care as a duty from us.

An Ethics of Care – basic proposition

An ethics of care, as the name suggests, places 'care' at the center of our ethical deliberations. As a formal ethics, it has had and continues to have considerable influence in the fields of medicine and education (Conradi & Heier, 2014). It is an ethics that endeavours not only to guide us as to how we should approach life and each other, but also how we should set up our institutions and communities (Conradi & Heier, 2014).

Some of the key terms used in the formulation of an ethics of care, which we will reflect on to make sense of the theory, are (inter)relationships, vulnerability and compassion. Proponents of an ethics of care represent Paul Ricoeur's consideration that our natural condition as 'social beings' is not one of autonomy but rather 'mutual dependence' (Baart & Vosman, 2011). What this means is that self-dependence and reliance is not a natural position for us as human beings and should be reflected in

our institutions, including our ethics and physical institutions. This has interesting consequences, as the focus for ethical decisions and moral character therefore need to answer for, if not be built upon, our relation to each other and our world.

Noddings, an influential author and educator, typically uses the mother-child relationship to elucidate the necessity for care as ethical principle (Brugere, 2014). The premise is that all human beings start their lives in a condition of vulnerability and a social relationship of dependence (Vanlaere & Gastmans, 2011). Without a caregiver, the child cannot survive let alone thrive. We all start our existences as vulnerable beings entirely dependent on the social relationships around us. The relationship, however, is not seen as one directional and meaning is drawn for the caregiver in providing care. Here Tronto, a respected professional ethics and political theorist, expands on Nodding's reference for care and defines care as follows:

“We suggest that caring be viewed as a species activity that includes everything that we do to maintain, continue, and repair our “world” so that we can live in it as well as possible. That world includes our bodies, ourselves, and our environment, all of which we seek to interweave in a complex, life-sustaining web” (Tronto as cited by Burgere, 2014)

Tronto therefore expands on the metaphor and social construct of the mother-and-child relationship to clearly emphasise the focus on interrelationship of people and the world as being at the heart of an ethics of care (Burgere, 2014). It is not only ourselves and our bodies in need of care, but our entire environment - both social and physical. As with birth, our demise is also exemplar of a requirement for care. As we grow older and even pass away, we require others to care for our physical bodies as well as our memory (Woods, 2014). We are vulnerable, mutually dependent on one another and our environment for survival and growth, and therefore should care for others seeing as ‘I require care’. This also ties with the African ethical maxim of Ubuntu, “Umntu ngumuntu ngabantu” - I am because we are. I can only be because of others, and therefore have a duty towards others. In ethics of care, the duty is care.

Aside from our interrelationships and vulnerability that forms the foundation for the justification for an ethics of care, it requires compassion as a principle for its implementation. Many theorists criticise the applicability of ethics of care on the basis of relationships of vulnerability and dependence being asymmetrical in nature and therefore harmful on some level to individual interest (Grypdonck, 2011). To clarify this in simpler terms, we can look at the teacher-student relationship. Whilst the learner is completely dependent on the teacher for guidance and quality learning, the teacher is not dependent on the learner for the same. Not in the same way, at least, according to ethics of care proponents. The issue for the opposition to ethics of care is that the two parties are not equal in the relationship of vulnerability. The exchange is a one-sided one – the learner is vulnerable and in need of tremendous care, the teacher has to provide such care. What then of personal interest and ‘care’?

The error for ethics of care proponents lie in the neglect of mutual dependence and is resolved with a principle of compassion. The issue of asymmetry is for ethics of care a flawed one, they hold that the asymmetry-relational view is based on a ‘cost-

benefit' view of the world (Grypdonck, 2011). For them it may be true that relationships may be asymmetrical on multiple grounds, such as power or information etc in the case of the teacher compared to the learner. However, the asymmetrical-dependence view neglects the basic proposition that we are all 'interwoven' and interdependent (Burgere, 2014). To see such relationships only in terms of 'cost-benefit' exchanges neglects the fact that gains are made on other levels, such as meaning and social welfare. Here is where compassion enters into the discussion.

Theorists in support of ethics of care have argued that compassion is the means by which we ensure 'care' is exercised as duty towards other human beings and our environment (Leget, 2011). Within the framework of an ethics of care, compassion is not only a 'feeling' for or 'empathy' towards others (Leget, 2011), although it includes this. Compassion is also a recognition of one's own vulnerability and those one instinctively care for, such as family members and peers. Compassion is also the recognition that the 'other' is 'you', a vulnerable and mutually dependent being, and to act caringly toward them is to act caringly towards yourself. Compassion for others, is compassion for the self – as it is a communal and long-term investment for maintaining, developing and repairing our world (Burgere, 2014). To 'care' is to act in a way that, if applied as 'rule' by others, would ensure care is returned to yourself and your community (Leget, 2011). It is also the opportunity to extend yourself, your meaningful being, by being part of the growth and protection of the 'other' (Joost, 2011). In terms of teaching, then, caring for your learners means also having the 'opportunity to care' and extending your being to be part of their potential growth as caring persons.

Ethics of Care and education

There are many consequences following the establishment of an ethics of care for education. Two worth mentioning are the welcoming of diversity and concern for individual development in education.

An ethics of care would require educators to actually 'care' for their learners, take interest in their wellbeing, development and participation in their education (Noddings, 2005). Noddings admits to the reality that 'care' may not be reciprocated by the learner(s)(2005), but holds firm that care can only follow if learners are cared for. If educators 'care', the school 'cares' and the community 'cares', then the learner is empowered to 'care' for themselves and others. This entails that educators should be welcoming towards diversity and promote discussion and participation from all learners and in diverse forms. For authors such as Noddings (2005), we are too diverse as individuals in our needs and interests to expect that our established and generalised approaches to education could ever serve to properly assist our learners to grow. Standardised testing, rigid curriculums and classrooms without learner input are indicative of a lack of care. Worse still, those generalised approaches meant systems that lead us, the educators and education institutions, astray. For her (Noddings, 2005), these approaches shifted our focus to marks and other

administrative ends, and the manipulation thereof, instead of the dire need to develop our learners and prepare them properly for their role(s) in society.

For an individual to develop there has to be care shown for their participation and their place in the classroom. For Noddings (2005), this also means that a caring educator would assist a learner to develop according to their skill and developing learning opportunities to develop those skills. To care as teacher is not to focus on an external end to be met, but a focus on the development of the learner on individual level. To accept that certain abilities and skills will not be obtained by learners, but that they can adopt specific aspects of a subject field that can benefit them in their personal development towards being effective participants in society. As an example, it may be futile to expect all learners to develop skills in doing complex, abstract mathematics. However, they can be taught mathematics to a level that assists development of their personal abilities. For Noddings (2005), the only way to ascertain what a learner's individual ability and needs are and to react responsibly through tuition, one first needs to care.

Moral education

All the philosophical justification aside, what does this mean for us as educators?

Noddings summarises moral education in the context of an ethics of care as entailing four major components (2005): modelling, dialogue, practice and confirmation.

Modelling requires the educator to present themselves as a caring educator (Noddings, 2005). As with the existing expectation of educators to be examples to their learners, modelling requires the educator to apply care in their interactions with their learners but also their field. Within a framework of care, it is doubly important that the learner experiences 'care' in order to develop a caring character (Noddings, 2005). Presenting a character of care is therefore not sufficient, and the educator must approach the learner on individual level with 'care'. In terms of their field, the educator must also express a genuine interest in their subject and teaching practices – the need to demonstrate care for their subject as well as their learners. Learners pick up quickly when a teacher does not care for a subject and will then be equally doubtful of the care directed to them (Noddings, 2005).

When referring to dialogue, it does not simply mean the conversational sense with the allowance of questions here and there (Noddings, 2005). Noddings invokes Paulo Freire when referring to dialogue, meaning dialogue as a genuine approach of openness to people, events and the world (2005). Dialogue in the context of moral education involves permission and opportunity of all involved to try and show themselves and their trepidations, educational or otherwise. It is a sincere openness to establishing relationships that welcomes individual diversity and a mental inquisitiveness that endeavours first to explore events and people fairly, rather than judge immediately from an existing personal narrative or established framework. It involves allowing the other to also bring their experience and knowledge to the table and through discourse determine its applicability, rather than immediately rejecting personal experiences as part of learning for not fitting the established mould (ex. It does not fit the textbook description neatly)(Noddings, 2005).

When referring to practice, Noddings (2005) suggests that practices of care has to become a norm in the classroom and the school environment. It extends beyond modelling, and requires subject groups, classrooms and the school to be involved in 'care'-events. The ideal is not only that learners experience events where other carers practice the act of caring, but be involved in events and occurrences where there is a need for care so learners can come to experience and understand the need (Noddings, 2005). It therefore moves beyond the act of caring and requires opportunity for learners to experience the interdependent nature of our world and their ability to contribute.

Finally, there is confirmation. Through care a person receives confirmation that they are worthy (Noddings, 2005). In the school environment, confirmation is key not only to stress for learners that they are worthy, but also able. Able to participate and even contribute to their world. Through confirmation we inspire to affirm and promote the best in others (Noddings, 2005). This also brings us to a very important point regarding an ethics of care: it may come across that caring through dialogue and confirmation may motivate morally dubious or bad behaviour to be understood and accepted. This, however, is false. We require open dialogue with ourselves and our world not to *not judge at all*, but to be clear where our judgements spring from and where they may need to be adjusted. In terms of confirmation, it means to also affirm when behaviour is wrong. However, a caring educator would attempt to ascertain the reasons behind bad behaviour and decisions, so as to confirm why it is judged negatively. Noddings shares a few examples in her book *The challenge to care in schools* (2005), where she expresses the relief when a learner is shown to be understood as to where their behaviour went wrong and that a 'caring' educator would provide disparagement of bad behaviour without admonishing the character of the child. For example: Martha is caught by Ms Dlavane bullying another child, even hitting the child in front of her friends and peers. There is no doubt that the behaviour is unacceptable and straightforward wrong. However, as educator, Ms Dlavane has two options – immediate punishment for bad behaviour and addressing Martha's bad character. Or, Ms Dlavane can try to come to understand Martha's reasoning and then guide as to why those actions are misguided. It may be out of petty jealousy, a friendship lost or social isolation; whatever the reason, the learner can be guided as to where they went wrong and how to become a better version of themselves. This does not mean punishment is removed, but rather caringly applied. Typically, if a learner is shown to be understood, even when their actions are misguided and immoral, there is a sign of relief (Noddings, 2005). When engaging in dialogue rather than outright judgement, and when there is confirmation made that better judgment and moral character is possible, the learner benefits from a caring teacher. They get to think: "Here is the significant and percipient other who sees through the smallness or meanness of my present behaviour a self that is better and a real possibility (Noddings, 2005:25)"

Care is therefore more than a specific type of act, it is a way of being, acting upon others, assisting others and approaching our lives and profession. It is a form of ethics that endeavours not only to ensure that all receive the care required to be efficacious individuals in their society, but also a form of ethics that assists the

reshaping of our individual characters and our social institutions to be better versions of ourselves for a better world for us all.

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